tickets and intimating the ETA to the incumbent. This whole process takes about a year and that is why the interview had been conducted in end-2006.

The language course at the SFL was a bit of a disappointment. The teaching methodology adopted was more suited to children rather than adults. There was a requirement of learning the alphabet no doubt, but the aim should have been to impart functional proficiency for the job of a DA. Moreover, Myanmar being a tonal language, it was impossible to get the accent right while sitting in India. Besides this, once I returned home after classes, who was I to practise with? Where was the milieu or the stimulus? This was a far cry from how I had learnt French as a child and only strengthened my conviction that a language can best be learnt residing in that country itself. When the time came for the written exam, while we had been taught from a printed text, the question paper was handwritten. It is like learning upper case and being tested in lower case. I was to relieve Col JS Chopra (Artillery) and when he came on leave, he gave a detailed briefing on various functional and administrative aspects, including the schooling system. There was a system of international schools, where the medium of instruction was English but it followed either the British or the US system. University education, though, was entirely in the vernacular. This meant that Isha, who was already pursuing her History (Hons) from Sri Venkateshwara College in New Delhi, would perforce have to stay back. Amala, in the tenth standard, would be halfway through her eleventh by end-2006, so what was to be done? I had my sister's experience at the back of my mind, how her studying in France had charted the course of her career, and thought it would be better if Amala were to move with us. Amala, like Isha, would rather have continued in the same school, but she understood the pros and

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